It was no secret that Srivastava was one of Karunakaran's favourite police officers.

GETTING READY FOR FRANCE

'I am sure you can handle this.'

According to the French deal, scientists and engineers of ISRO and SEP would jointly develop the rocket engine, and India would provide a little more than fifty people at any time for the hundred-man year project. SEP would assign our men for 75 man years and I would lead the rest of the team which would put in 25 man years. The project later got extended to 135 man years.

Getting the deal signed was quite an achievement for me, given the inherent opposition to the development of liquid propulsion systems, which the 'solid guys' thought was way outside our sphere of capabilities. It was gratifying that Sarabhai and Dhawan saw merit in my argument for developing liquid systems. Some said they agreed to try for the French deal just to get rid of 'Nambi the nag', thinking that the deal would never come through. Whatever the bosses' intention were, I had won a small battle here.

But the challenge had just begun. The first task was the selection of the team of more than fifty scientists and engineers who would go to Vernon. Given the aspirations, competition and a fair amount of internal politics made it a tough job.

Pessimism about the liquid engine project pervaded top down in the organisation, which was so used to focusing only on solid propulsion systems. But, at least at the lower and middle rungs, getting into the joint venture team was a big dream. A few were genuinely interested in the challenge to learn a new technology; fewer understood its future applications; many just wanted to go to France.